

BIRDS OF PREY



Long broad wings with finger-like tips

MOST BIRDS OF PREY, INCLUDING EAGLES, hawks, and falcons, kill and eat live animals. They soar high above the ground or dart among trees, using their excellent eyesight to search for their prey. Once they spot a victim, they attack with their sharp talons, then tear up their food with their hooked beaks. Not all birds of prey feed in this way.

A few species eat unusual foods, such as snails or nuts.

Vultures eat carrion – animals that are already dead. They often wait for another animal to make a kill and then swoop down to the ground to feed on the remains of the carcass.

At the end of a dive, the falcon opens its wings to slow down.

The falcon controls its flight by moving its long wing feathers.

Eyes

Birds of prey have superb eyesight for spotting prey on the ground from high up. Their eyes face forwards, which makes the birds good at judging distances. This is essential for a bird such as the lanner falcon, because it has to know exactly when to brake as it hurtles toward its prey.

Beak

Birds do not have teeth, so they cannot cut meat into pieces before they swallow it. Instead, birds of prey tear up their food with their beaks. Despite the ferocious appearance of a bird of prey's beak, it is hardly ever used as a weapon.

Widely spread flight feathers brake the falcon's flight as it makes an attack.

Bird of prey features

With their forward-facing eyes, sharp claws, or talons, and hooked beak, birds of prey are perfectly adapted for hunting and feeding on meat. Most species have feathers covering the upper legs. These are for warmth and protection.

Lanner falcon

This falcon lives in desert and savannah areas of southern Europe, Africa, and the Middle East. Like other falcons, it catches prey by folding its wings back and falling on it in a steep dive. Falcons also attack birds in mid-air by diving on them from above.

Tail feathers are used to steer in flight.

Talons

Birds of prey have large feet with long toes. Each toe ends in a talon, which stays sharp by flaking into a point as it grows. The birds use their talons to kill food, and carry it away. Many species can lift more than half their own weight.



Chukar partridge is prey of the falcon.

Hovering

Kestrels hover close to the ground while looking for prey. This uses a lot of energy, but the kestrels can dive quickly on anything that moves below them.

Flight path of goshawk



Splayed feathers reduce air turbulence.

Flight path of kestrel

Kestrel can see small animals on the ground.

Long, narrow wings

Flying styles

Most large birds of prey, such as eagles, look for food while soaring on currents of rising air. This uses little energy, allowing the birds to fly long distances every day. Smaller species, such as hawks, usually fly in short bursts. Kestrels are unusual in being able to hover in the air.

Broad, rounded wings

Long, broad wings

Flight path of eagle

Soaring

Eagles, buzzards, and vultures soar by riding on currents of rising air. They spiral around slowly as they soar upwards, keeping their wings straight and steady.

Low-level flight

Hawks usually hunt by flying in short bursts. They are highly manoeuvrable, and can swerve between trees and over hedges, using surprise to catch small birds.